(missiles, submarines and aircraft). Air Marshal S.B.P. Sinha (retd) says that armed with long-range Meteor missiles, Rafale is themost potent fighter in the region. "This will force adversaries on the defensive till the time they can identify the absence of the Rafale amongst IAF strike packages," he says.

The IAF's strategic transport aircraft, like the fleet of 11 US-made C-17 Globemaster and 12 C-130J Super Hercules ensure swift movement of equipment and supplies to airbases close to the LAC. The Russian origin Ilyushin Il-76, Antonov An-32 and the German Dornier 228 are part of IAF's transport inventory.

The latest entry, the C-295, is a massive shot in the arm. Capable of carrying up to nine tonnes of payload or as many as 71 troops along with their equipment and vehicles at a maximum speed of about 480 km, the C-295 can also be used for air-to-air refuelling of choppers and fixed-wing aircraft. The second aircraft is due to be delivered in May 2024 and the next 14 rolled out at a rate of one per month until August 2025. The first 'Made in India' C-295 will arrive in September 2026. All aircraft are scheduled to be delivered by August 2031.

When it comes to its rotary fleet, India has 15 American CH-47F Chinook transport helicopters that operate along with the Russian origin Mi-26, Mi-8, Mi-17, Mi-17 1V and Mi-17V 5 transport copters. For a strike role, the IAF has 22 US-made multi-role Apache attack helicopters, and is acquiring 66 of the highly praised indigenous HAL Prachand Light Combat Helicopters. Along with the Rudra Advanced Light Helicopters, they enable IAF to perform day/night, all-weather attack missions, especially in the mountainous border areas with China. Air Marshal Sinha adds that Apache is the most potent attack helicopter in the world, capable of annihilating enemy's armoured forces even at high altitudes.

NORTHERN OPPONENTS

CHINA

- **Fighter jets (No.: 1,215)** J-10B/C, J-11B, J-16, Su-30 and J20. Also developing fifth generation fighters like J-20 and FC-31/ J-31
- **Transport fleet (238):** Y-20 and Russian-made Il-76 aircraft
- **Early warning aircraft (64):** KJ-2000 Mainring AWACS and airborne early warning and control (AEW&C) aircraft **KJ-200 Moth** (Shaanxi Y-8), and KJ-500 (Shaanxi Y-9)
- **Helicopters (65): WZ-10** attack helicopters, Mil Mi-8 and Harbin Z-9 utility helicopters, and Changhe Z-8 transport/ utility helicopters
- **UAVs: Yunying** (CloudShadow), Gongji 1, CH-4 and CH-5 and Yilong (Wing Loong)



INTEGRATED INTELLIGENCE

A nationwide integration of radars is being undertaken to create a centralised control centre under the Integrated Air Command and Control System (IACCS) of the IAF. The IACCS can use data from space-based platforms, airborne aircraft sensors, video from surveillance drones and pictures from airborne warning and control systems (AWACS) and airborne early warning and control (AEW& C) aircraft. The IACCS integrates ground-based sensors of the IAF, army and navy.

Perfectly aligned with its expanding fighter jet inventory is the growing missile arsenal of the IAF—from the deadly BrahMos to Beyond Visual Range (BVR) missiles. Besides the British Advanced Short Range Air-to-Air Missile (ASRAAM), which is being integrated with Jaguar and Su-30MKI, the indigenous BVR missile Astra Mk-1 and Mk-2—that can engage targets between 10 and 110 km—will be inducted by 2023-end.

Apart from ground attack missiles like the French AS-30 and the Russian Kh59 cruise missiles, Israeli long-range air-to-air Python 5 and French MICA missiles have been added to the IAF's arsenal. Used in the Balakot strikes, SPICE 2000 air-to-ground missiles and HAMMER air-to-ground precision-guided weapon systems can pulverise enemy targets.

The three regiments of Russian S-400 air defence systems—which can track and neutralise incoming aircraft—are a potent threat to Chinese bombers, surveillance AWACS aircraft and fighters. However, the remaining two regiments of the S400 have been delayed due to the ongoing conflict in Ukraine. "With its long reach, the S-400 will force the adversary's surveillance aircraft like AWACS, reconnaissance and refueller aircraft away," Air Marshal Sinha says.

In any future conflict, Artificial Intelligence-supported UAVs will be vital—flying independently, in a swarm or with manned aircraft. The IAF has Israeli Heron and Searcher UAVs and Harpy and Harop loitering munitions. A total 31 of the American MQ-9B SeaGuardian and SkyGuardian drones, superb in both reconnaissance and strike roles, are expected to arrive in the coming years.

Robust in defence, the IAF today has long-range precision strike capability and the ability to exercise dominance over a wide region. "IAF prides itself for its reach, responsiveness and offensive lethality. All top-end fighters refuel in the